

MUSIC REVIEW

Fusion Raga

If Indian classical music needs a youth icon as the face of the future, Niladri Kumar, 37, fits the bill perfectly. Trained by his father Pandit Kartick Kumar, the senior most disciple of Pandit Ravi Shankar, Kumar is a fifth-generation sitar player as it was his grand-

father's grandfather who struck the first note in the family. "When people ask me how many years I've been learning, I say 250 years for that is the time our family has been playing sitar," he adds.

Kumar's album *Priority*, a world music album, is a departure from the usual fusion albums. He has created a new sound with his innovative instrument, Zitar. He says, "Zitar has its soul in Indian classical music. The goal is not to change Indian classical music, but to draw the attention of audience and music channels towards this and create a craving for this purest form of music."

In this album, Kumar has included musical minds like Sanjeev Abhayankar (vocals), Murad Ali (Sarangi), Rakesh Chaurasia (flute) and others to give a different feel to the compositions. The number *Babur comes to India* is a tribute to all those who kept the faith during the invasion;

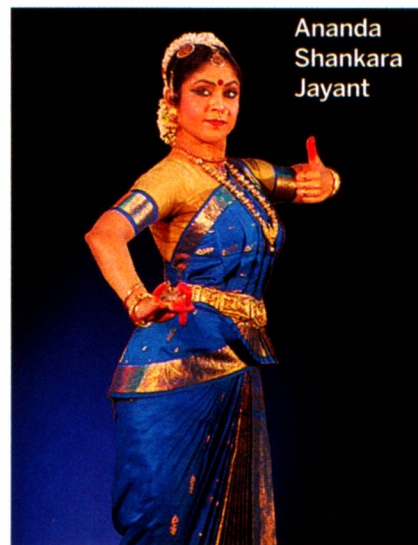
Take it easy captures the New York state of mind and *Zilebration* is a celebration of life. Kumar has an interesting anecdote on why he named his album

Priority. "Whenever I went abroad for a show, the airline crew would put two stickers on my sitar case saying 'fragile' and 'priority'. The 'priority' tag in particular appealed to me as it attached a certain level of importance to the instrument. That is why I named the album and even a track as *Priority*," he says.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit



PRIORITY
NILADRI KUMAR
Rs 199
Sa Re Ga Ma.



Ananda
Shankara
Jayant

FESTIVAL

Epic
CULTURE

Sri Krishna Gana Sabha in Chennai is one of the most awaited annual events. For this year's Natya Kala conference, the convenor of the festival, noted danseuse Dr Ananda Shankara Jayant, has chosen the *Ramayana* in the performing arts as the concept. "Senior artists and scholars will explore different facets of the epic through traditional and modern interpretations," she says. Performers, academicians and choreographers like Sonal Mansingh, Padma Subramanyam, Prof Chandrashekar, Swapasundari, Anita Ratnam, Navtej Singh Johar are expected to participate. The styles being showcased are Bharatanatyam, Bharatanrityam, Odissi, Kuchipudi, Kathak and other contemporary dance forms. Besides dance, music will play a major role in the festival. A discussion, *God and the Musician*, will explore spirituality and the modern musician. *Sita sings the blues*, an award-winning animation film by Nina Paley, exhibition and sale of Cherial(scroll) painting will also be part of the conference. December 17 to December 23 in Chennai.

by Nirmala Ravindran